Infantry Brigades, fell back behind the Salween River to protect Rangoon, where it was reinforced by the 46th Infantry Brigade. The Japanese Fifteenth Army's 143rd Regiment crossed the Salween River on February 8, 1942, and built a roadblock on the Martaban-Thaton Road. The next day the Japanese attacked and captured Martaban. Further north the 33rd Division attacked and defeated the 7th/10th Baluch Regiment on February 11–12, 1942, forcing the withdrawal of the 46th Infantry Brigade to Rangoon. The loss of two brigades meant that Rangoon could not be defended. General Harold Alexander, the recently appointed commander of the Burma Army, ordered the city of Rangoon to be evacuated after the port and oil refinery had been destroyed to prevent capture by the Japanese. As the British began their retreat north from Rangoon they destroyed much of Burma's infrastructure, including rail lines, river boats, and communication networks to prevent them from being used by the Japanese.

THE RETREAT FROM RANGOON

After the fall of Rangoon, the IJA reorganized and began an offensive designed to pacify Upper Burma. The 55th Division followed the route to Toungoo, while the 33rd Division went up the Ayeyarwaddy valley toward Prome. By the middle of March, the 55th Division, aided by the BIA, had inflicted a heavy defeat on the Seventeenth Indian Light Division at the Sittang Bridge, cutting off several British and Indian units before they could be pulled back across the Sittang River. The Japanese were then able to seize Pegu, cutting railroad links leading north out of Rangoon. In the Ayeyarwaddy valley, the 33rd Division pushed past Prome toward the oil fields at Yenangyaung. On April 14, 1942, retreating British and Indian forces set the oil field ablaze to prevent them from falling into Japanese hands.

After reaching Toungoo Japanese forces divided into two columns, the 55th Division continuing northward toward Mandalay, while the 18th Division made a flanking move along the Mawchi-Loikaw Road. By mid April, the 18th Division dislodged the Chinese from the area around Loikow. This left the entire left flank of Allied forces exposed. There was little chance that the poorly armed British, Indian, and Burmese forces could continue to hold their lines. The remainder of the campaign was a rout. In fact, there was the real chance that Allied forces would be isolated